sixty missions, and forty-two countries had their diplomatic representatives in Delhi. By the 1970s India had 112 missions abroad, which grew to 140 foreign missions during the 1990s. As of 2015 India has 162 embassies and consulates abroad.[40]

Retired diplomats often complain that, unlike the United States and some others, India lacks a formal system to train its diplomats for service in specific countries. Training by the Ministry of External Affairs provides a broad framework, leaving several things – such as learning languages, local customs and history – to the discretion of individual diplomats. Envoys are supposed to return to Delhi before taking their next appointment but it is not mandatory. Most diplomats lament the relatively small size of the foreign service, which does not allow foreign service officers reorientation time between postings. They argue that diplomats must be given an opportunity to return to Delhi and brainstorm with key stakeholders (not only at the ministry and the PMO but also at other ministries) during and between serving abroad. The counter-argument is that the ministry cannot micromanage a diplomat's understanding of the country where he or she serves and officers must be allowed to learn on their jobs.

There are approximately 770 IFS officers manning 162 Indian missions and posts abroad as well as at headquarters in New Delhi. For a country of its size and the demands of global engagement, India has a relatively small foreign service. The Ministry of External Affairs also has 400 support staff, including interpreters and lawyers who are not foreign service officers. These numbers do not compare favourably with other major developing countries. China has 6,000 diplomats while Brazil's foreign service comprises 3,000.[41] 'For every Indian diplomat there are four Brazilian diplomats,' Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon told a parliamentary committee in 2007. 'For every Indian diplomat there are seven Chinese diplomats,' he said and added, 'Now we might be wonderful and very